Reducing Crime: Evidence-Informed Recommendations

Based on the Global Crime Intelligence & Public Safety Analytics dashboard

Data: World Bank (homicide series sourced from UNODC) and Eurostat. Retrieved 2026-11-04. Prepared 5 November 2026.

Executive summary

The dashboard covers 195 countries with reported homicide data (2000-2023) plus Eurostat police-recorded offences for about 40 European jurisdictions. Homicide is the only crime type with worldwide country-year data, so the analysis and the recommendations below are anchored on **lethal violence**, with Europe-specific notes on property and sexual offences.

What the data says

- **Violence is highly concentrated.** Latin America and the Caribbean average 21.1 homicides per 100K (all reported country-years), versus 2.1 to 4.8 in the lowest regions. The ten highest-rate countries on average are El Salvador, Honduras, Jamaica, Venezuela, Lesotho and five others.
- **Violence is male.** The mean reported rate is 14.6 per 100K for men and 2.4 for women, about 6 times higher. The picture for women differs in where they are killed (see recommendation 6).
- **Inequality, not average income, lines up with homicide.** Across 152 countries, higher Gini goes with higher homicide (r = 0.56); GDP per capita (r = -0.11) and unemployment (r = 0.17) show weak links. These are associations between countries, not proof of cause.
- **Big falls are possible, and so are big rises.** El Salvador fell from 107.6 to 7.9 per 100K (2015 to 2022); Ecuador rose from 12.3 to 45.7 (2012 to 2023).
- **The global trend cannot be read after 2020.** Countries reporting fell from 157 (2010) to 83 (2023), so the 2023 uptick in the weighted rate partly reflects who reports.

Priority recommendations

#	Recommendation	Where the dashboard points
1	Concentrate resources on the highest-burden places and people	Regional and country ranking (Page 2)
2	Use focused deterrence and violence interruption for the small group driving lethal violence	Male-to-female gap (Page 3)
3	Restrict illicit firearms and strengthen trafficking enforcement	Highest-rate countries; organised-crime share in the Americas
4	Build investigative and prosecution capacity against organised crime, with rights safeguards	El Salvador, Colombia, Honduras case studies
5	Invest in youth risk reduction and in lowering inequality	Gini association (Page 4)
6	Treat violence against women as a separate, home-based problem	Eurostat partner/family homicide data
7	Regulate alcohol and expand drug treatment	Evidence base (external)
8	Keep property-crime gains and improve sexual-violence reporting and response (Europe)	Eurostat offence trends (Page 3)
9	Fix the data so progress can be measured	Coverage collapse after 2021

Important: this dataset measures outcomes, not interventions. The recommendations combine patterns in the dashboard with published evaluation research (sources at the end); none of the figures here shows that a policy caused a change.

1. What the dashboard shows

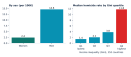
Trend and coverage. The population-weighted homicide rate for reporting countries fell from 7.8 per 100K in 2000 to 4.6 in 2020, then rose to 8.0 in 2023. Coverage fell sharply over the same period (117 countries in 2000, 157 in 2010, 83 in 2023), so only the 2000-2020 comparison is reasonably stable.



Geography. The Latin America and the Caribbean average is about seven times that of the lowest regions and more than double that of Sub-Saharan Africa. Averages by income group are upper middle income 12.6, lower middle income 8.8, high income 5.4, low income 4.6 - upper-middle-income countries have the highest mean rate, while low-income countries report fewer homicides, which may partly reflect weaker recording.



Who is affected, and inequality. UNODC reports that men were 81% of homicide victims and 90% of suspects in its global study, consistent with the male-to-female gap here. The inequality quartiles below use country averages for 2000-2025.



Change over time. Countries do move. In the dataset, El Salvador, Honduras, Colombia, Venezuela, Guatemala all show falls of roughly 50% to 90% from their peak, while Ecuador, Haiti, St. Kitts and Nevis and Costa Rica rose sharply after 2012. The data cannot say why.



2. Recommendations

Each recommendation lists the signal in the dashboard, the action, the external evidence, and the dashboard indicator to monitor.

1. Concentrate resources on the highest-burden places and people

Signal in the data	Latin America and the Caribbean average 21.1 per 100K; the highest-rate countries (El Salvador, Honduras, Jamaica, Venezuela, Lesotho) average 33 to 56. Violence is also usually concentrated in a few neighbourhoods inside each country, which national data cannot show.
Actions	Allocate prevention budgets and police capacity by measured burden. Build city and neighbourhood homicide maps. Use problem-oriented hot-spots policing with community partners rather than generic patrol increases.
Evidence base	Campbell systematic reviews find hot-spots policing effective, with crime-prevention benefits diffusing to nearby areas, and larger effects for problem-oriented approaches (Braga et al.).
Track on dashboard	Country Rank, Highest/Lowest Rate, Regional comparison (Page 2).

2. Focus on the small group at highest risk (focused deterrence, violence interruption)

Signal in the data	Men face a rate about 6 times that of women, and UNODC reports men are 90% of suspects.
Actions	Identify the few people and groups driving most shootings; combine a clear deterrence message with social services, job support and credible community messengers. Pair with cognitive behavioural therapy for high-risk young men.
Evidence base	Focused deterrence programmes are associated with medium-sized crime reductions in Campbell reviews. A J-PAL/Stanford review lists CBT, multidimensional therapy, addiction treatment, focused deterrence, alcohol controls and hot-spots policing as having strong evidence for violence prevention.
Track on dashboard	Male Homicide Rate, Male to Female Ratio (Page 3).

3. Restrict illicit firearms and strengthen trafficking enforcement

Signal in the data	UNODC reports organised crime accounts for about 22% of global homicides and at least half in the Americas, where gun availability amplifies lethality.
Actions	Tighten licensing and storage rules, trace every recovered firearm, prosecute trafficking networks and share intelligence across borders. Prefer enforcement and regulation to buyback schemes.
Evidence base	UNODC links organised groups to firearm procurement through dealers, black markets and military stocks. A meta-review finds firearms enforcement moderately effective and buybacks not (Abt).
Track on dashboard	Homicide Rate for the Americas; add firearm-share data when available.

4. Build investigative and prosecution capacity against organised crime, with rights safeguards

Signal in the data	El Salvador (107.6 to 7.9), Colombia (70.4 to 24.9) and Honduras (83.2 to 31.4) show that rates can fall; Ecuador and Haiti show how fast they can rise.
Actions	Invest in detectives, forensics, witness protection and case management; reduce case backlogs and cases with unknown perpetrators; target leadership and finance of groups rather than mass arrests. Evaluate every strategy for rights impact and durability.
Evidence base	UNODC reports that many homicides have unknown perpetrators and recommends reducing criminal-justice backlogs. El Salvador's fall coincided with extraordinary measures that have drawn human-rights criticism; the dataset cannot show what caused the fall or whether it will last, so treat it as a case to study, not a template.
Track on dashboard	YoY Change, Historical trend (Pages 1 and 3).

5. Invest in youth risk reduction and in lowering inequality

Signal in the data	Gini shows the strongest link (r = 0.56, 152 countries); the median rate in the most unequal quartile is 11.8 versus 1.4 in the least unequal. GDP per capita (r = -0.11) and unemployment (r = 0.17) show weak links.
Actions	Do not rely on growth alone. Expand early-childhood and school-retention programmes, CBT-based youth programmes, family support and quality jobs for young people in high-burden areas.
Evidence base	The meta-review finds family-based programmes moderately effective, while school-based and vocational programmes have unclear effects unless well designed. These are cross-country associations and may reflect other factors.
Track on dashboard	Homicide vs Gini, GDP and Unemployment scatter charts (Page 4).

6. Treat violence against women as a separate, home-based problem

Signal in the data	Eurostat records in 2015-2024 show women are about 67% of victims in the partner/family homicide category in Europe (label to be verified). Global rates for women are low (2.4), so national rates hide this pattern.
Actions	Fund risk assessment for police and health workers, rapid protective orders, shelters, specialised courts and perpetrator programmes; record victim-offender relationship in every homicide case.
Evidence base	UNODC reports women are 54% of victims of killings in the home and 66% of victims of intimate partner killings, and estimates nearly 48,000 women and girls were killed by partners or family members in 2022.
Track on dashboard	Female Homicide Rate (Page 3); Eurostat partner/family victims (Europe).

7. Regulate alcohol and expand drug treatment

Signal in the data	Alcohol and drugs are associated with violence in the evaluation literature, although the dataset has no substance-use indicator.
Actions	Limit hours and density of alcohol sales in high-violence areas, raise taxes, and fund treatment and diversion (drug courts) rather than relying on drug-law enforcement alone.
Evidence base	The J-PAL/Stanford review finds strong evidence for alcohol controls and drug treatment; the meta-review finds drug treatment effective and drug enforcement not.
Track on dashboard	Add alcohol and treatment indicators if available.

8. Keep property-crime gains and improve sexual-violence reporting and response (Europe)

Signal in the data	Between 2010 and 2023 median police-recorded rates fell for robbery (50 to 22 per 100K), burglary (475 to 182), theft (1412 to 686) and vehicle theft (90 to 37). Recorded rape rose in most jurisdictions (median 5.6 to 12.6; fell in only 6 of 33).
Actions	Sustain situational prevention (locks, lighting, vehicle immobilisers, CCTV where evaluated). For sexual violence, invest in victim services, trained investigators and prosecution, and measure prevalence with victimisation surveys, because police counts also rise when reporting and legal definitions improve.
Evidence base	Campbell reviews find improved street lighting, CCTV and hot-spots policing effective for crime prevention. Eurostat notes law changes and reporting practices affect recorded sexual offences.
Track on dashboard	ES Offence Rate per 100K, Europe offence chart (Page 3).

9. Fix the data so progress can be measured

Signal in the data	Countries reporting fell from 157 in 2010 to 83 in 2023; 2024 and later have no homicide data in the files; the World Bank series has no counts, sex-by-age detail, mechanism or city detail.
Actions	Support national statistics offices to report to UNODC on time; publish homicide by sex, age, weapon, relationship and city; add victimisation surveys; use the ICCS definitions consistently; report missing years rather than filling them.
Evidence base	UNODC reports that many homicides lack information on the perpetrator, and four in ten killings of women lack the victim-perpetrator relationship.
Track on dashboard	Data Coverage %, Countries with Homicide Data (Page 1).

3. Where to start: priorities by country group

Group (dashboard)	Signal	Suggested focus
Latin America and the Caribbean, highest-rate countries	Mean 21.1 per 100K; top-10 countries 33-56	Recommendations 1-4; firearms and organised-crime strategy; city hot-spot programmes
Countries with recent sharp rises (e.g. Ecuador, Haiti, St. Kitts and Nevis, Costa Rica)	Rates up by 9 to 33 points since 2012	Early warning on organised-crime expansion; prison and border controls; rapid response to gang activity
Sub-Saharan Africa	Mean 8.9 per 100K; coverage thin	Strengthen recording first (rec. 9), then inequality and youth programmes (rec. 5)
Upper- and lower-middle-income countries	Highest income-group means (12.6 and 8.8)	Inequality, policing quality, firearms controls
Europe and Central Asia, high-income countries	Low homicide; property crime falling; recorded rape rising	Rec. 6 and 8: domestic violence response, sexual-violence services, organised-crime watch
Countries that fell sharply (El Salvador, Colombia, Honduras, Venezuela, Guatemala)	Falls of about 50% to 90% from peak	Study what worked, check durability and rights impact, keep investing in prevention

4. Monitoring framework

Use the dashboard measures to judge progress each year. Always show coverage next to the rate.

Indicator (dashboard measure)	Direction	Note
Homicide Rate per 100K (country)	Down	Compare same country across years, not countries with different recording
Weighted Homicide Rate (reporting countries)	Down	Read together with Countries with Homicide Data
YoY Change (per 100K)	Negative	Use a 3-year average; one-year changes are noisy in small countries
Male to Female Ratio, Female Homicide Rate	Stable or down	Women: also track partner/family killings
Data Coverage %	Up	Without coverage, falling rates may just be missing data
Europe: offence rates (robbery, burglary, rape)	Property down; sexual offences: interpret with surveys	Recorded rape can rise when reporting improves

5. Limitations

- The data are country-level aggregates, not incident records. They describe patterns and cannot show that a policy or an inequality level caused a change.
- Homicide rates come from the World Bank series sourced from UNODC; UNODC files themselves failed to download and are not in the project. Crime types other than homicide exist for Europe only (Eurostat).
- No crime data exist for 2024-2026 in the files. Coverage drops after 2021, so global trends after 2020 are unreliable.
- Low-income countries report lower averages than middle-income countries; this may reflect weaker recording rather than lower violence.
- Eurostat counts differ across countries in recording stage and legal definitions; recorded rape and sexual violence are affected by law changes and reporting behaviour. ICCS labels for several codes and the relationship categories are marked "to verify" in the dataset.
- The effectiveness evidence cited comes mostly from studies in high-income countries (as noted in the meta-review); results may differ elsewhere. Strategies with high rights costs need independent evaluation.

6. Dashboard quality notes (from the four page screenshots)

These issues affect how the figures should be read and are worth fixing before sharing the dashboard.

Page	Observation	Suggested fix
1	The bottom-right trend chart repeats the top-right one; the band chart is not in band order; Data Coverage shows 0.90	Replace with Countries with Homicide Data by year (shows the coverage drop); sort bands by band_order; format coverage as %
2	Country Rank card (53) and the multi-country line chart have no meaning without a country selection; map title mentions rate bands but plots rates	Default to one country or a short list; rename titles. Lowest Rate card shows Senegal 0.00, but the lowest country average in the file is Senegal (0.27) and Senegal has one value (0.27 in 2015): check the Lowest Rate measure
3	Recorded Homicides (Eurostat) shows 112K because the year slicer spans 2008-2024; the Europe offence chart shows one bar	Use a single year or label it cumulative; chart ES Offence Rate per 100K by offence_name with the offence_code filter
4	Scatter charts show about six bubbles, not about 190 countries; correlation cards are absent	Put country_name in Values (not "First country_name"); add the three Corr measures as cards
All	Year slicer is set to 2000-2025, so cards show all-year averages	Use a single year for ranks and highest/lowest; show the selected year in each title

Sources

UNODC, Global Study on Homicide 2023 (key findings on organised crime, victims and relationships). UNODC, launch speech of the Global Study on Homicide, 8 December 2023 (firearms procurement, 48,000 women and girls killed by partners or family in 2022). Braga, Papachristos and Hureau, Hot spots policing effects on crime, Campbell Systematic Reviews 2012. Braga and Weisburd, Focused deterrence strategies and crime control, Campbell Collaboration. J-PAL and Stanford CDDRL, What works to prevent violence among youth. Abt, What works in reducing community violence, meta-review presentation (2018). Eurostat, crime and criminal justice metadata (crim). World Bank, indicator VC.IHR.PSRC.P5 and World Development Indicators. All dashboard figures come from the master dataset built from the World Bank and Eurostat files.